

Lesson Plan — French Revolution

History | Grade 9-10 | Intermediate | French Revolution

Overview

Subject	History
Grade band	9-10
Topic	French Revolution
Chapter	French Revolution
Source document	French Revolution
Periods	9 x 40 min

Learning Objectives

- [remember] Recall the commonly given start and end dates of the French Revolution and cite the document's phrasing.
- [understand] Explain how social, economic and political factors combined to produce a crisis that led to the calling of the Estates General in 1789, using evidence from the text.
- [analyze] Analyze the causes and consequences of the Reign of Terror between 1793 and 1794, and summarize why the Thermidorian Reaction followed.
- [apply] Apply evidence from the chapter to describe two ways newspapers or symbols (e.g. La Marseillaise, the cockade) influenced public perception during the Revolution.

Period-by-Period Plan

Period 1: What was the French Revolution? Definition & Causes

Concepts	French Revolution (definition), Causes of the Revolution (overview)
Objectives	Recall the commonly given start and end dates of the French Revolution and cite the document's phrasing.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (10 min), Guided group discussion / role play (15 min), Check for understanding (5 min), Consolidate & bridge to next lesson (5 min)
Why this order	This opening period establishes the standard start/end dates and an evidence-based overview of the Revolution's long- and short-term causes. It prepares students to evaluate primary events next (Estates-General and National Assembly; Storming of the Bastille; Abolition of feudalism and August Decrees).

Period 2: From Estates-General to August Decrees

Concepts	Estates-General and National Assembly, Storming of the Bastille, Abolition of feudalism and August Decrees
Objectives	Explain how social, economic and political factors combined to produce a crisis that led to the calling of the Estates General in 1789, using evidence from the text.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (10 min), Practice/source analysis in pairs (10 min), Role-play debate in small groups (10 min), Check for understanding (3 min), Consolidate (2 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the prior overview of the Revolution's definition and causes by explaining how the Estates-General crisis (May–June 1789) and the popular violence at the Bastille (14 July 1789) forced the National Assembly into radical action; it prepares students to evaluate the Assembly's later reforms such as the Civil Constitution of the Clergy and the fall of the monarchy.

Period 3: From Constitutional Monarchy to Republic Crisis

Concepts	Civil Constitution of the Clergy and confiscation of church property, Constitutional monarchy period (July 1789–3 September 1792), Flight to Varennes and impact on monarchy, Insurrection of 10 August 1792 and fall of the monarchy
Objectives	Explain how social, economic and political factors combined to produce a crisis that led to the calling of the Estates General in 1789, using evidence from the text.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (10 min), Role play and perspective taking (12 min), Group discussion analysing competing interpretations (6 min), Check for understanding (5 min), Consolidate (2 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the Estates-General, Bastille, and August Decrees by showing how the Revolution shifted into a constitutional monarchy and then collapsed after the Flight to Varennes; it prepares students to analyse the Republic's proclamation and Louis XVI's trial next.

Period 4: From Republic Proclamation to Louis's Execution

Concepts	Proclamation of the First Republic (September 1792), Trial and execution of Louis XVI, Committee of Public Safety
Objectives	Explain how social, economic and political factors combined to produce a crisis that led to the calling of the Estates General in 1789, using evidence from the text.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (10 min), Role play & debate (12 min), Group discussion of interpretations (6 min), Check for understanding (5 min), Consolidate and extend (2 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the fall of the monarchy and the controversies of

the Constitutional Monarchy period taught in 'From Constitutional Monarchy to Republic Crisis' by explaining how the Convention proclaimed the Republic, tried and executed Louis XVI, and created the Committee of Public Safety. Understanding these events makes possible a study of the government and violence that follow in 'Reign of Terror (Sept 1793 – July 1794), Thermidorian Reaction and the Directory, Coup of 18 Brumaire and the Consulate'.

Period 5: Reign of Terror to 18 Brumaire

Concepts	Reign of Terror (Sept 1793 3 July 1794), Thermidorian Reaction and the Directory, Coup of 18 Brumaire and the Consulate
Objectives	Explain how social, economic and political factors combined to produce a crisis that led to the calling of the Estates General in 1789, using evidence from the text.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (10 min), Debate / role play (12 min), Practise source analysis (7 min), Check understanding (4 min), Consolidate (2 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the Republic proclamation, Louis XVI's trial and the Committee of Public Safety by examining how the Reign of Terror produced political instability; it prepares students to evaluate the Fall and execution of Robespierre, the Thermidorian reaction, and how that instability led to the Directory and ultimately the Coup of 18 Brumaire and the Consulate.

Period 6: Thermidor, Law of 22 Prairial, Directory

Concepts	Fall and execution of Robespierre; end of the Terror, Law of 22 Prairial (10 June), Thermidorian reaction and aftermath, Constitution of the Year III and the Directory's institutions
Objectives	Analyze the causes and consequences of the Reign of Terror between 1793 and 1794, and summarize why the Thermidorian Reaction followed.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (6 min), Introduce new material (10 min), Structured debate/role play (12 min), Check understanding (6 min), Consolidate and link forward (6 min)
Why this order	This period takes students from the Reign of Terror's end (the fall and execution of Robespierre and the repeal of the Law of 22 Prairial) toward the new constitutional order established by the Constitution of Year III and the Directory, preparing them to evaluate how the Thermidorian reaction shaped later military, political and economic developments under the Directory.

Period 7: Directory, Wars, and Colonial Emancipation

Concepts	French Revolutionary Wars: mobilisation and territorial gains, Political and economic challenges of the Directory (1795-1799), Abolition of slavery in the colonies (1794), Role of newspapers and pamphlets
Objectives	Analyze the causes and consequences of the Reign of Terror between 1793 and 1794, and summarize why the Thermidorian Reaction followed.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (6 min), Introduce new material (8 min), Group discussion & source comparison (14 min), Role-play debate (6 min), Check and consolidate (6 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the fall of Robespierre, the end of the Terror and the Constitution of Year III (Thermidor, Law of 22 Prairial, Directory) by examining how the Directory governed amid war, press activity, and abolition; it prepares students to analyse Revolutionary symbols and economic crises in the following lesson (La Marseillaise; guillotine; symbols; role of women; assignats and inflation).

Period 8: Symbols, Terror, and Economic Crisis

Concepts	La Marseillaise (national anthem), Guillotine as symbol of the Terror, Revolutionary symbols: cockade, tricolore, and liberty cap, Role and repression of women in the Revolution, Assignats, price controls and inflation
Objectives	Apply evidence from the chapter to describe two ways newspapers or symbols (e.g. La Marseillaise, the cockade) influenced public perception during the Revolution.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (8 min), Guided preparation for role-play/debate (8 min), Structured role-play/debate (12 min), Check for understanding (4 min), Consolidate and reflect (3 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the prior study of newspapers, mobilisation and the Directory's political and economic challenges (Directory, Wars, and Colonial Emancipation) by tracing how songs, symbols and the guillotine shaped public opinion and how assignats and price controls produced popular hardship. It prepares students to evaluate the Revolution's long-term effects and to study the guillotine and assignats in greater depth in the following unit (Long-term impact of the Revolution on France and Europe; Guillotine; Assignats).

Period 9: Revolutionary Symbols, Sources, and Legacy

Concepts	Long-term impact of the Revolution on France and Europe, French Revolution (topic and bibliography), Guillotine (as a subject of study), Assignats (economic instrument discussed)
Objectives	Apply evidence from the chapter to describe two ways newspapers or

symbols (e.g. La Marseillaise, the cockade) influenced public perception during the Revolution.

Time allocation

Activate prior knowledge (5 min), Introduce new material (8 min), Group debate / role play (12 min), Practice source analysis (8 min), Check for understanding (5 min), Consolidate (2 min)

Why this order

This period builds directly on 'Symbols, Terror, and Economic Crisis'—using the prior lesson's focus on La Marseillaise, the guillotine, the cockade, and assignats to move from events to interpretation. It prepares students to synthesize the Revolution's long-term impacts on France and Europe and to evaluate historiography through the bibliography and competing scholarly views.

Concepts Taught

Concept	Importance	Summary
French Revolution (definition)	core	The French Revolution was a period of political and societal change in France that began with the Estates General of 1789 and ended with the Coup of 18 Brumaire on 9 November 1799.
Causes of the Revolution (overview)	core	The Revolution resulted from multiple long-term and short-term social, economic, financial and political factors culminating in crisis in the late 1780s; resistance to reform by the ruling elite and indecisive policy by Louis XVI contributed.
Estates-General and National Assembly	core	The Estates-General convened in May 1789; representatives of the Third Estate broke away and reconstituted themselves as a National Assembly in June 1789.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Storming of the Bastille	core	The Storming of the Bastille occurred in Paris on 14 July 1789 and led to a series of radical measures by the Assembly.
Abolition of feudalism and August Decrees	core	The Assembly published the August Decrees which abolished feudalism, cancelled church tithes, and enacted equality before the law and other measures.
Civil Constitution of the Clergy and confiscation of church property	supporting	The Assembly confiscated church property to back assignats and enacted the Civil Constitution of the Clergy (12 July 1790), making clergy state employees and requiring an oath that divided the church.
Constitutional monarchy period (July 1789 3 September 1792)	core	From July 1789 to September 1792 the Revolution established a constitutional monarchy framework, created a constitution and limited political rights to 'active citizens'.
Flight to Varennes and impact on monarchy	supporting	King Louis XVI's attempted flight to Varennes in June 1791 discredited the monarchy and increased suspicion, leading to demands for oaths and preparation for war.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Insurrection of 10 August 1792 and fall of the monarchy	core	Military defeats and growing insurrection culminated in the insurrection of 10 August 1792, resulting in the replacement of the monarchy by the French First Republic in September 1792.
Proclamation of the First Republic (September 1792)	core	On 22 September 1792 the Convention replaced the monarchy with the French First Republic and introduced a new calendar with 1792 as 'Year One'.
Trial and execution of Louis XVI	core	Louis XVI was tried, sentenced to death on 17 January 1793, and executed on 21 January 1793.
Committee of Public Safety	core	The Committee of Public Safety, created 6 April 1793, became the executive committee dominating the Convention and led the government during the Reign of Terror.
Reign of Terror (Sept 1793 – 3 July 1794)	core	From September 1793 to July 1794 the Terror saw around 300,000 arrests and approximately 16,600 people executed on charges of counter-revolutionary activity.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Thermidorian Reaction and the Directory	supporting	The Reign of Terror ended in July 1794 with the Thermidorian Reaction; the Committee of Public Safety was replaced in November 1795 by the Directory.
Coup of 18 Brumaire and the Consulate	core	The instability of the Directory ended in 1799 with the coup of 18 Brumaire and the establishment of the Consulate with Napoleon Bonaparte as First Consul.
Fall and execution of Robespierre; end of the Terror	core	Robespierre was arrested after being denounced by members of the Convention, attempted suicide, and was executed on 28 July along with colleagues; the Law of 22 Prairial was repealed and the Jacobin Club closed thereafter.
Law of 22 Prairial (10 June)	core	A law that denied 'enemies of the people' the right to defend themselves and contributed to a dramatic increase in executions in Paris.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Thermidorian reaction and aftermath	supporting	After Robespierre's fall (Thermidor) there were revenge killings in southern France, execution of Commune leaders, but some former Terror actors retained positions; treaty and military successes helped end certain insurrections.
Constitution of the Year III and the Directory's institutions	core	The 1795 constitution created a bicameral legislature (Council of 500 and Council of Ancients) and a five-member executive (the Directory) with deputies chosen by indirect election and property qualifications.
Political and economic challenges of the Directory (1795-1799)	core	The Directory faced unrest, economic weakness, and relied on army force to resolve deadlocks; corruption and use of military interventions characterised its governance until the coup of 18 Brumaire.
French Revolutionary Wars: mobilisation and territorial gains	core	From 1792 the Revolution led to large-scale national mobilisation (conscription), major battles like Valmy and Jemappes, and territorial annexations such as the Austrian Netherlands and Batavian Republic by 1795.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Abolition of slavery in the colonies (1794)	core	The Convention voted to abolish slavery in the colonies on 4 February 1794, granting full rights to colonial residents irrespective of colour; commissioners in Saint-Domingue had begun emancipations earlier.
Role of newspapers and pamphlets	supporting	Newspapers and pamphlets were central to stimulating and defining the Revolution; over 130 newspapers appeared in 1789 and more than 2,000 were founded in the following decade.
La Marseillaise (national anthem)	supporting	A song composed in 1792 by Claude Joseph Rouget de Lisle, adopted by the National Convention as the First Republic's anthem in 1795 and widely used as a revolutionary song.
Guillotine as symbol of the Terror	core	The guillotine became the principal symbol of the Terror, invented as a quicker form of execution and became a part of popular culture and public spectacle.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Revolutionary symbols: cockade, tricolore, and liberty cap	supporting	Cockades (blue-and-red of Paris) and the Liberty (Phrygian) cap were widely used symbols linking the Revolution to republican and classical traditions.
Role and repression of women in the Revolution	supporting	Women initially participated in activism and organized societies, but 1791 and 1793 constitutions denied them political rights; in October 1793 women's clubs were made illegal and organized women were excluded from politics.
Assignats, price controls and inflation	core	Church and émigré lands were nationalised and used to back assignats; excessive issuance and poor harvests led to hyperinflation, price controls, black markets, and withdrawal of assignats in 1796.
Long-term impact of the Revolution on France and Europe	core	The Revolution ended feudalism in France, promoted individual freedoms, stimulated nationalism, exported reforms across Europe (notably Napoleonic legal codes), and influenced constitutions and reforms in several countries.

Concept	Importance	Summary
French Revolution (topic and bibliography)	core	This section is a bibliography and sources list relating to the French Revolution, collecting books, articles, and online resources about its causes, events, interpretations, and legacy.
Guillotine (as a subject of study)	supporting	The guillotine is treated as a subject with dedicated literature; the bibliography cites a monograph titled Guillotine by Robert Frederick Opie and other works addressing execution and related practices during the Revolution.
Assignats (economic instrument discussed)	core	The bibliography includes literature debating the role and effects of assignats during the French Revolution, indicating that assignats are an economic topic of scholarly discussion.